



One for keeps: The Kerala footballers, including I.M. Vijayan (standing, extreme right), pose for a team picture before a match in 1967.

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into a tournament mostly for young players (in 2015), who didn't have other platforms to excel," he added.

The AIFF made it mandatory for teams to have five Under-21 players in the squad and three in the playing 11. It also decided not to allow the I-league, ISL (which had begun by then), and second-division players to take part in the Santosh Trophy.

Balan added that during Shaji Prabhakaran's tenure, the Federation decided to scrap the U-21 rule and allowed the reserve players from the I League, ISL, and 2nd division squads to play in the Santosh Trophy.

An underrated assembly line

As a national tournament for state federations, it has become an underrated assembly line for young players to find a footing in professional football.

Manvir Singh and Liston Colaco, two Indian Super League — winners with ATK Mohun Bagan (now called Mohun Bagan Super Giant), were both part of their respective sides — West Bengal and Goa — in the Santosh Trophy in the 2016–17 season.

Manvir scored the winner against Colaco's Goa in the final to win the title.

"A lot of developmental work over the years has yielded results in the states, and we see a lot of improvement in the standard of Indian football," Charles Dias, the current coach of Goa, told Sportstar.

"That is a good sign, which you can already see happening in the Santosh Trophy."

M. Satyanarayanan, the acting General Secretary of the AIFF, further added that while the ecosystem of club football has shifted towards corporate ownership, the co-existence of the same with legacy tournaments will ensure the success of football in India.

"In our country, club football and inter-state football are different. Club football is more individual efforts of private entrepreneurs or corporates with deep pockets, which cannot be compared with an inter-state event where the initiative lies with the state associations," he said.

"Club football and inter-state

football will have to coexist. For example, we have U-13 and U-15 events for clubs in Khelo India games, whereas the AIFF has also started the U-13, U-15, and U-17 leagues for the states."

The Santosh Trophy, adapting to modern football demands in its 83-year-long history, remains a vital platform for nurturing talent.

Phijam's recent selection among the potential players for India's under-23 team underscores its significance in grooming promising players alongside established leagues like ISL and I-League.

"The Santosh Trophy used to be the pinnacle of Indian football in our playing days. I feel today, the tournament is all the more important," former Indian forward and manager Shabbir Ali told the AIFF website.

"Because it gives representation to more states than the Hero ISL or the Hero I-League. They all need to be on the football map. You can't leave out so many places in such a big country."

« The Santosh Trophy has become an underrated platform for youngsters to find a footing in professional football »»